

POINT OF VIEW · 2026

Don't digitise the *mess*.

A point of view for operations and technology leaders on Lean, automation and the M³ framework.



THE ARGUMENT

Automation rewards the *prepared*.

Why the sequencing of Lean and automation decides whether the digital budget compounds or evaporates.

Automation is the easiest budget line to approve and the easiest to waste. Regional operations leaders are under instruction to digitise. Vendors are willing. The risk is not moving too slowly. It is paying to encode today's inefficiency at scale, then paying again to run it.

You cannot automate what you cannot see. Most banks hold their processes in the heads of supervisors and in outdated SOPs. The M³ framework captures process flows, controls and risks in a living digital twin of operations, so every decision about what to automate rests on evidence rather than anecdote.

Lean first. Then digitise. Applied front to back across primary loans and credit processes in London and New York, this discipline eliminated manual waste before a single tool was bought, and released \$150M in capital through process redesign alone.

“*We prevent the costly mistake of digitising the mess.*”

M³: the *operating* discipline.

01

The M³ framework

A structured enterprise process management tool capturing flows, controls and risks: a living digital twin of the bank's operations.

02

Lean + automation

Lean principles eliminate waste first; digitisation follows. Every automation dollar delivers real ROI rather than encoding inefficiency at scale.

03

Pod-based delivery

Cross-functional pods of process engineers, tech developers and change agents run rapid sprints with measurable weekly outcomes.

04

Granular diagnostics

Proprietary tooling identifies value-destructive activity at process level, with Gold Standard SOPs for compliance.

CASE STUDY

\$25M

COST SAVINGS REALISED

Front-to-back Lean optimisation

A global bank, primary loans and credit

THE CHALLENGE

Manual waste across primary loans and credit processes in London and New York, with capital tied up in inefficient RWA allocation.

WHAT WE DID

A comprehensive front-to-back Lean review: eliminating manual work, redesigning credit processes and optimising RWA allocation.

THE OUTCOME

\$25M in cost savings and a \$1.1Bn RWA reduction, releasing \$150M in capital through disciplined process redesign.

\$25M
Cost savings realised

\$1.1Bn
RWA reduction

\$150M
Capital released

Four moves before the next automation *dollar*.

01

Map before you buy

Build the digital twin first. No automation case without a process baseline.

02

Take the waste out

Apply Lean to eliminate manual work before any tooling decision is made.

03

Automate the clean process

Digitise what has earned it. Measure ROI on every automation dollar.

04

Deliver in pods

Cross-functional sprints with weekly, measurable outcomes. Quick fixes ship in weeks.

Leading with clarity.
Delivering the *difference*.

Start a conversation

ABOUT ASPIRO

Aspiro is an independent, investor-free management consultancy for GCC financial institutions, founded in Dubai in 2015 with offices in Riyadh and London. Its partners carry 100+ years of senior leadership experience, backed by a network of 8,000+ specialists.

info@aspiro.me · +971 5230 8566 · aspiro.me · Dubai · Riyadh · London